fifties with India (when it was on friendly terms with Communist China and the Soviet Union)."[169]

The administration also disengaged from efforts to improve India-Pakistan relations, despite continuing to believe that this could help Delhi alleviate the "more immediate threat of military pressure from China." After trying earlier in 1967 to get India and Pakistan to reach an arms limitation agreement, the State Department concluded, "We cannot bring about reconciliation no matter how hard we try." Rather, it was best to focus on strengthening relations with each country. From Washington's perspective, maintaining a relationship with Pakistan did not exacerbate India's China problem, as Delhi believed, but helped limit it. The administration wanted Delhi to recognize that it was in neither American nor Indian interests for the US to cede the ground in Pakistan entirely to China.[170]

American disengagement was facilitated by the US belief by summer 1967 that Indian defense preparations were sufficient. An intelligence assessment noted that India was not just likely to be able to win any war with Pakistan, but that it "could also probably repel a Chinese attack before it could reach the Indian plains. We believe that India's armed forces would be able to prevent a major breakthrough by combined Chinese-Pakistani forces equipped with conventional weapons, though they might have to yield ground in Ladakh and northeastern India."[171] This view was reinforced by the Indian performance that September in the first major clashes between China and India since the 1962 war. There was a fair amount of focus in the US on the clashes in Sikkim, to assess both the likelihood of escalation and Indian military preparedness. When Indian deputy prime minister and finance minister Morarji Desai, who was visiting the US, appeared on the *Today* show, the first five questions were about the fighting.

American officials followed developments closely. American and Indian military and diplomatic officials exchanged assessments in Delhi, Washington, and Calcutta, including perplexity about Chinese motivations. Indian officials stated that they believed Chinese actions were localized, but deliberate. The CIA director asked his staff for better reporting on the Sino-Indian border situation. Updates on the Nathu La clashes made Johnson's daily brief each day between September 12 and 15, and then again after a clash took place at Cho La on October 1.